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Slide Hampton

Trombonist and arranger Slide Hampton was born on April 21, 1932 in Jeannette, Pennsylvania. He has performed with Woody Herman, Maynard Ferguson and Dizzy Gillespie, and played a major role in Gillespie's United Nations Orchestra. His arrangements have been performed by numerous ensembles including the Carnegie Hall Jazz Band and the Collective Black Artists' Orchestra.

Slide was interviewed in West Orange, New Jersey on July 30, 2003 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are in West Orange, New Jersey for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive. I'm very pleased to have Slide Hampton with me today. And you know an interviewer is not supposed to tell stories, but I must tell you that a couple of years ago I heard your band at the Iridium.

SH: Oh yes.

MR: And I happened to get a seat that was right at the end of the saxophone section. And I was able actually to see the music. And I saw this passage coming up. I said this is totally impossible. They cannot play this. And not only did they play it but the whole band, in unison, played this lick that I was just astounded at.

SH: "Night in Tunisia."

MR: Yes. I could not believe they pulled it off. You write some challenging music.

SH: When we first played that and Paquito D'Rivera heard that he said, "God, what was that?"

MR: It was a unison lick, right?

SH: Yeah. I actually made it up — it was actually a sort of a copy from the Charlie Parker break that he had made.

MR: Yeah. That was great. I just had to tell you that, that it certainly made an impression.

SH: Well we just played that arrangement — not that arrangement, another arrangement of "Night in Tunisia" when I was in Holland a couple of weeks ago. And when I got ready to give them that break too but I didn't have the courage to give it.

MR: Really. So you do have some sympathy for where you are at and who is playing the music?

SH: Oh yeah. You have to adjust you know. Because if you find a real enthusiastic bunch of guys then you give them any difficult music. And they're glad to have the challenge. Other guys, "Oh man, this is difficult," you know.

MR: Well you have done both small group and big band music. Is there a place that you're most comfortable in?

SH: You know you're thinking — of course I've been asked that question many times and most musicians are. But see the thing is that we actually were raised in the big band period. And all the musicians that you hear playing the small groups that we aspired to, like Charlie Parker and Dizzy Gillespie and Benny Goodman, Stan Getz, they all were raised in the big band period. And that was what prepared them so well to be so well presented in small groups, that big band experience. So actually we find both of them as important, but of course you can enjoy yourself in one way in a small group because you get to improvise more. And in the big band you have the wonderful experience of playing in the ensemble with other people, which is very important and wonderful also.

MR: It might seem obvious to musicians what that positive experience of being in a big band is, but maybe for non-musicians who might see this tape, can you relate what kind of things you gain from that?

SH: Well you know what people think when they see a person in a big group, they think that it is a kind of a situation that's so well organized that it would kind of prevent you from being free enough to improvise. It's not the case at all. Actually because improvisation is certainly a free style of playing music, but there is a lot of organization that goes on in an improvisation. To have a good improvisation there's a composition that goes on, a certain amount of theory, a certain amount of all the things that you actually learned also in the large ensembles.

MR: Hearing your note in place with everything else, I mean really helps your ear doesn't it?

SH: It does. And you hear the resolutions of the harmony, harmony of arrangements that are written by great arrangers. I remember when I played with the Dizzy Gillespie group and I was playing arrangements by Quincy Jones, by Dizzy himself, Ernie Wilkins, Melba Liston, Benny Golson. You learn about resolutions in the big group, because you hear all these resolving harmonies and things. So when you improvise you also use resolutions as a big part of the way that you make an improvisation.

MR: That's a great point. When you were growing up, did you have a musical family?

SH: My mother and father, all my sisters and brothers were musicians. I was raised in Indianapolis which was a wonderful musical environment, because Freddie Hubbard was there, Wes Montgomery, J.J. Johnson, and just a lot of guys that were really very, very talented musicians that never became known. But we had a wonderful environment and the people there were very supportive of young people becoming musicians, in the high schools, marching band, they were very encouraging to us. So we were raised in an environment of music. In our family band we traveled throughout the country playing places.

MR: Kind of — what were the venues? Were they dances or just parties and that kind of thing?

SH: At one time all the venues that big bands, actually most of them were usually places that people were dancing. That was a big part of the inspiration for the music in general. Write something that will make the people dance. Because it's a little backwards than the way it was in classical music. When you heard classical music you heard music that is actually coming from a dance. First it was a dance and then there was the music.

MR: Like the gavotte. Those things.

SH: Yeah. Yeah see?

MR: That's a great point.

SH: And in jazz, first it was the music and then there was the dance you see. So that was a very inspiring part of it but we also finally played at Carnegie Hall, Apollo Theater, and again the Savoy Ballroom, where everybody is dancing again, like a thousand people are dancing, the floor is going up and down like this. And actually we played the Apollo, and then we went in the Savoy for two weeks, and we came, by popular demand, back in the Apollo again. And nobody ever did that. And the thing was that see in the Apollo you have these big shows. You have a lot of music. We didn't read music. We had a couple of brothers that read but the rest of us didn't read. They had to teach us the part. So we would learn the parts by memory and we played the show. And the people, they loved it.

MR: That's really neat. What year would this have been?

SH: That was in the early — well I guess like in the early fifties.

MR: Uh huh. And they could be — the Apollo could be, let's say, unkind to people they didn't like? Is that true?

SH: They were kind of outspoken. If they didn't like something they would say so. And actually it was a good point because it really did make people, when they went there, it made them do their very best. And some big stars actually from those talent shows came out of those talent shows. Because the competition was always so high. But if they liked you they would let you know it. And if they didn't like you they would let you know.

MR: I see. When did you first get the urge to become an arranger?

SH: Well you know somebody was just asking me that question, and in the case of us, which are all the guys in Indianapolis, David Baker was there and of course J.J. Johnson, we all started to learn to arrange right with learning to play the instrument. Because we thought in order to be a complete musician you had to learn about theory, you had to learn about orchestration, you had to learn about arrangements, you had to learn about playing in the ensemble. So this was all a part of becoming a musician for us. And so the arranging everything came out along with learning to play the instruments.

MR: I see. So it wasn't really just like this separate decision, I can play now and then I need to be a writer too. Kind of just hand in hand?

SH: In the case of many guys it was like that. But in our case, they fooled us right from the beginning and said you guys got to learn all of this right away. And we thought it was true, and we tried it.

MR: And who was telling you this, your teachers?

SH: The teachers. Oh yeah. They were teaching you theory and everything right from the beginning. In like in general, in the environment, you know we just had this great inspiration to try to learn how to arrange and to orchestrate. It was, a lot of it was a decision we made ourselves, we just wanted to know these things.

MR: Sure. Who were the influences on the trombone for you back then?

SH: There were many. At that time there were many trombone players that were very popular. Later in the fifties and sixties you started not to hear much of trombone players anymore. But in the forties and fifties there were a lot of trombone players that were popular. There was Tommy Dorsey, there was Trummy Young, there finally was J.J. Johnson, there was Jack Teagarden, there was Lawrence Brown. A thousand guys you know. So we were listening to all of them and actually we wasn't really thinking about having a favorite. We were just loving all of it and learning, enjoying listening and learning from all of them.

MR: Neat. You were, let's see, you were born in '32?

SH: Yes.

MR: And do you recall anything different about your family life during the World War II years?

SH: Well all my brothers went in the Army. And of course they were all in bands in the Army. You know that was very lucky for them. But they saw also some of the war action too, some of them did, and they told me about how it was and everything. But they did a lot of studying, being in the Army bands, and got to actually rub elbows with a lot of great musicians and they learned a lot being there, and they came back even more developed in the areas of reading music, playing in the ensembles and writing music and all of that.

MR: Were they overseas?

SH: Yes.

MR: You know we're so used to almost instant communication nowadays. We almost forget about that it must have been tough on your parents to like wait for letters from the sons.

SH: For some reason we never had a thought of any of them getting hurt in the Army.

MR: Really.

SH: We did have one brother that got hurt but I mean he had to go in the hospital, but we never thought of losing anybody. We never thought like that. Our family was so — my mother and father were such wonderful people. What I remember about my whole childhood is just being in a very wonderful environment of people that had a wonderful

way of relating to each other. They taught me just a wonderful thing about attitude and all of that. And our attitude was that we knew they were gonna come back. No matter what happened, we knew they were coming back. And they did.

MR: Was the church part of your upbringing?

SH: Oh yeah. My mother used to make me go to church every Sunday. I couldn't get away from Indianapolis soon enough so I didn't have to do that anymore. She had me in church all day.

MR: Oh. All day. Was it a musical church?

SH: It always had some music but it wasn't like some of the churches that you go — like in Philadelphia there are some churches that got some choirs, and some of them actually have musical bands and things there. It was all singing and all but in our house there was music every day.

MR: I see.

SH: We were practicing and rehearsing every day. And all the people from the neighborhood were coming around. And the kids would come, and some of them would come in and learn about being musicians. My father was teaching everybody. He was a fantastic man.

MR: Oh. And did he have work besides music too? During the day?

SH: He did. My father could do everything. He was a great painter. He painted beautiful pictures. He was a carpenter. He was a school teacher. He did everything. That's when you had that big family, he was actually very idealistic. Most people wouldn't try to raise a family man, he had about ten kids you know. Most people wouldn't try that. He didn't think that was anything. He really felt as though he could handle that with no problem, because he could do so many things. And he did. He took care of us from the time that we were — until we were ready to leave home with no problem.

MR: That's wonderful. Do you have photos from back then?

SH: I was just looking at my father and mother's photos before I came here today, and a picture of our family band, one when I was very young and I wasn't playing, I was dancing and singing in the band, and then one when I was older playing trombone.

MR: That's so interesting. Did you have people for a rhythm section, the whole—

SH: Oh yeah. We had the rhythm section and everything right there in the family.

MR: That's neat. I sometimes wonder in those kind of situations your parents are thinking well let's see, we need a saxophone player so—

SH: I think that's the way it was. They finally needed a trombone. I was the last one born into the family.

MR: Oh, you were the youngest.

SH: So they said we need a trombone player. You're going to play trombone. And your name will be Slide whether you like it or not.

MR: Does that go back that far?

SH: Yeah.

MR: Your nickname?

SH: Yes. From the time I started. I started actually playing trombone at 12. And when they gave me the trombone they gave me the name.

MR: Is that right?

SH: Yeah.

MR: Because, is your name Locksley Wellington?

SH: Yes.

MR: Yeah I got that out of the *Grove Dictionary*.

SH: Yeah. Not many people know that.

MR: Yeah. Okay. That's really interesting, that they pinned that on you right away. Well nicknames help too.

SH: Oh yeah.

MR: That's great. Did you feel a need at a certain age to, you mentioned getting out of Indianapolis. Time to spread your own wings a little bit?

SH: Well see when we played the Apollo Theater we had such success that the booking agents wanted us to stay in New York. And we would have had a good success in New York. But my sisters wanted to go back to Indianapolis. You know how ladies are. And so we didn't stay. And after I was in New York the first time I remember when I was there I went to Birdland to hear Bud Powell play. That was it for me. I had to come to New York after that. And that's all I talked about from that time until I got to New York is I have to go to New York. And I just had this great feeling for New York. And all I could think about was how can I get to New York. So I finally left Indianapolis on my way to New York, fifteen dollars in my pocket. So I only got as far as Cincinnati, Ohio. But I played with Miles there. Played with Miles for a weekend. And then some friends found out that I was in Cincinnati. They were in Houston, Texas. They sent for me to come from Cincinnati to Houston. So I took a bus ride from Cincinnati to Houston, Texas. It was horrible. Long and painful and hot. And I stayed in Houston for a year playing, because they had a great job there. They played one night a week in a club and it was a big success. I played with that band until Buddy Johnson heard me. And then he came and took me to New York City.

MR: So you took the long way. Did you have your first arrangement played with him? With Buddy Johnson?

SH: Well actually — probably the first professional arrangement, yes.

MR: Yeah. Do you have the ability to sit at a desk like this and write?

SH: I used to.

MR: I mean do you need to be near a piano?

SH: I used to write without the piano. I wrote a lot of the arrangements, after I wrote for Buddy Johnson I wrote for Lionel Hampton and I wrote for Maynard. And a lot of the arrangements I wrote for Maynard I wrote without the piano. And those are recorded things. I was a young guy, you know, I had the energy that it takes to actually do that.

MR: Well speaking of that, I have to play something for you. Because it's something I really think is —

[audio interlude]

Do you remember this?

SH: You know I'd forgotten about this song.

MR: No kidding.

SH: "Mark of Jazz."

MR: "Mark of Jazz." Yeah. You were writing hot licks way back then too.

SH: Yeah. Maynard gave us a lot of opportunity to arrange and to learn about arranging. So we were inspired writing there in that band. So there were several guys that were writing a lot. Willie Maiden and Don Sebesky and a couple of other guys that were in the band. Then we were playing arrangements by great arrangers from other bands too.

MR: That was a hot group.

SH: Yeah it was. People really liked that band. We certainly did.

MR: This was '57ish.

SH: Yes.

MR: Did the group like that, being integrated, run into any problems?

SH: Not really. Not really.

MR: Glad to hear that.

SH: I think the only time that we had any problems like that was when we took a whole tour. It was Sonny Rollins and his quartet, or no it was the trio, and it was Dave Brubeck with his group, Maynard Ferguson's band. And then there was another, might have been The Four Freshmen or somebody like that. And we played really all through the south you know, because it was such a big thing that they would command everywhere for it. And we had some problems about finding places to eat and things like that once in a while. The whole thing wasn't like that, but once in a while it was. But when I was with Buddy Johnson's band, we couldn't eat at any of those places. We couldn't go in any hotels or anything like that.

MR: In what parts of the country?

SH: Well as soon as you get down below Washington I guess, down to Virginia, then it was all very difficult. But we were so much into the music, we weren't thinking about that you know. That's the wonderful thing about a lot of the guys that came before us, that

had more of those problems than we did. The music was so important to them that they just rode right through all of that. Music is like that. It's really wonderful. It's above everything. It's above wars, it's above racism, it's above everything. Because see in the war, the guys that were having the jam sessions in the basement in Germany, the Germans, if they had been caught they would have been killed. They were still having jam sessions, playing Charlie Parker or Duke Ellington in the basement with the windows covered with stuff so nobody would know. They took that kind of chance. That's how important the music was to them.

MR: That's right, 'cause that regime felt that jazz music was evil.

SH: Oh yeah. And there's a lot of music that they didn't allow the people to listen to or play. But jazz was so important to the guys that they had to play it anyhow. I played with a lot of those guys when I lived in Europe.

MR: Yeah you spent a number of years, almost nine years or so, in Europe. Was that a planned decision or did you go there and like it on trip or something?

SH: It was spontaneous. It wasn't planned. Impromptu. I was playing with Woody Herman. And at that time when you joined a band you didn't have any rehearsals or anything like that. You joined the band and you went right on the concert stage and played right there and you had to sight read everything and all of that. But we were always into that. Sight reading and all of that was a part of what we did for fun. When I was with Woody we played England for two weeks. And I have a very funny story with Woody because I was new in the band so his conducting I wasn't familiar with. You know? So I'm just trying to follow the conductor. Because I feel when you give a downbeat I'm playing. But I was playing alone when he gave it out. So every time he would give a downbeat I would play, bamm. And then the band would play after me. So I'm wondering what's going on, you know I said am I not seeing this right or what? So after the first week he came to me and said, "Slide, I'm paying you more money than anybody in the band. You're the only one that's playing wrong." I said, "I know it. I just can't figure out where your downbeat is." And I says, "Is it here, is it here?" And the guys told me later they said, "We don't play on his downbeat. He gives the downbeat and then we play when we think we should play." So I said I'd wait for them. And after I played with him for two weeks some people found out that I was in England. They said while you're over there come over on the continent of Europe and play some concerts over here. And I had never done this. And I didn't know the condition. I didn't know what the conditions would be. But they offered me such wonderful conditions. First class transportation, first class hotel, great money for the group and the concerts and everything. So I went over and played a few concerts and it was so unusual for me to be treated like that. I stayed for eight years.

MR: Wow. And playing mostly with European musicians?

SH: Sometimes with American musicians, sometime with European musicians. I played with Dexter Gordon, Johnny Griffin, Benny Bailey, oh just a host of guys that were living — Kenny Clarke. All the guys that were living over there and also with the European musicians. We made radio shows. Because see in every city in Europe there's a radio band that is subsidized by the government to play a certain amount of jazz every year.

MR: Isn't that something.

SH: That money — they can only use that money for jazz projects. And they have that same subsidy for classical music and for folk music. So we had a lot of radio shows and television shows and cultural houses where we were playing concerts and festivals and all that. So it was really a fantastic experience.

MR: And you were treated pretty darn well then.

SH: Treated really — I never had that kind of treatment before. It was a surprise to me.

MR: What prompted you to come back?

SH: Well after I stayed over there for a while then I was asked to come back to do this CD with Dexter Gordon. The "Sophisticated Giant" CD.

MR: Oh yeah. That's a good one.

SH: And for us it was a wonderful project. And I had worked with Dexter over there several times. He was just wonderful to work with. I had known of him before but I didn't know him before and I had no idea what kind of person he was or anything. But working with him was like heaven. He treated everybody — musicians and audience alike — with all the love in the world you know. So I learned a lot working with him from that. And when he asked me to come back and do that, and asked me to stay. And I came back and things were starting to change in America then. People were becoming interested in jazz again.

MR: Wasn't there a song on that record called "Fried Bananas?" Something like that?

SH: Yes. That's Dexter's original tune.

MR: Those are marvelous arrangements and it's such a nice sized ensemble, with the vibes in there, right?

SH: Yeah.

MR: Just — the colors are great on it.

SH: I could have done a much better job with the arranging.

MR: You think so?

SH: Yeah. I was shooting the stuff off and then not really getting it. I was shooting.

MR: Yeah. Well you're probably your own worst critic when it comes to something like that.

SH: Well you always — because you know when you have a chance to do something like that you really want to do something that has some real meaning and some real value. Because to get all of those guys together, because some of them were still living in

Europe and they were coming from all over the place and they had wonderful attitudes. They worked together very professional and very loving.

MR: And you would get not a lot of studio time, right? To pull something like that off?

SH: No you never get much studio time. In fact one of the CDs that we've done recently, we produced it ourselves, it's the first time that we've had enough time in the studio to really do it the way that we should. Because then it was always you were running through those things and you know they were trying to be as considerate as possible. But it can only go on so long then they'd say, "Listen, you've got to move on."

MR: Yeah. You have mentioned coming back and that the country seemed to be taking a little more interest in jazz music. That's interesting that you say that, because this was late seventies?

SH: Yeah.

MR: Was it the start of the educational interest in the music?

SH: Yes it was. That was one of the things that opened up to the jazz musicians. We were offered — I've been offered many jobs in universities. But I never went to high school so I couldn't take them. I'd have to tell the truth and say I'm not really — I don't have the credentials for this. You know I had the experience for it and things like that but I don't have the credentials and I'm not going to lie about a thing like that. But I would always, when I was offered a job like that I would recommend somebody that did have the credentials that also had the ability.

MR: Yeah. You know there's a lot of people who have the credentials though who don't have the experience so, I mean you have the real life, hands on experience, and that's worth a great deal.

SH: Experience is very important of course, and the thing that's most important of all is to be true to yourself. To tell the truth to yourself and to everyone else, that's very important. Because that's what improvisation actually is about. It's about saying what the truth is about your feelings and about your experience, and about what it is that you can do and what you can't do. The thing that improvisation does for me, it makes me realize that I don't have to feel bad about the things that I can't do, but I have to admit it. Because then it's an advantage to me. If I try to make myself believe that I can do things that I can't do, I'm being a disadvantage to myself. And improvisation is like that. It makes you admit the truth about yourself. The good and the bad. There's plenty of bad.

MR: That's a great thought. I really like the way you put that. I can envision getting in a position where you are expected to play in a certain style and it just wouldn't be you.

SH: Yeah.

MR: And trying to do it and it wouldn't last too long I would guess.

SH: I'm not good at playing in different styles. Unless it's something that I just feel to do because of the situation I'm in, I'm not good at being able to reproduce what other guys have done.

MR: If you were to describe the style you like to play in or your own trombone style, is it possible to put it into words?

SH: Yes, very easily. Because see the trombone, that instrument actually was — we kind of gave a false impression in many cases, because they would think about the circus. You know you hear the trombone [scats]. But the trombone actually was invented to play melodies. That's what it was invented for. And that's where it's the most beautiful is when it's playing melody. Because that's the strong point that I work on in my own development is the ability to play melodies and to make lines that I play of other improvisations sound melodious. Because there's one thing that I found out about people. They can relate to a melody. And especially one that they've already heard, but even if they haven't heard it and it's beautiful, they can relate to it. And once you've played one song that they know, everything you play after that they'll try their best to understand it. So that's my style, is trying to be melodious, and try to develop — I work on my sound. I want to have the most beautiful sound that I can. So when somebody hears it, even before they think about what I'm playing they say that sounds good. That feels good. That sounds good.

MR: Great thoughts again. You have like these things you're saying that ought to be put in stone somewhere.

SH: Thank you.

MR: What to you makes a good melody?

SH: Well like anything else, the construction of a melody. The way that it resolves naturally from one note to the other. And of courses you know you have a lot of practice in that all of the great people that came before you that wrote melodies. There's so many great melodies that started I don't know how long ago, a thousand years ago even maybe. But to have a melody that a person can listen to. I thought about that recently — a melody that a person can listen to that they never heard before but they still can appreciate it and enjoy it. The beauty of it. Of course you can always enjoy a melody that you know, if it's something that you like. But to be able to play a melody or to write a melody or compose a melody that people can listen to and say yeah I like that, although I haven't heard it before. I think that's one of the things that — the standards that I try to look for in playing or writing a melody.

MR: If I was to arrange for a commission for you and leave it totally wide open, maybe describe the instrumentation or something, but at any rate just say we want a Slide

Hampton composition but we want a new thing. Where do you start with something like that?

SH: Well I've been asked the question many times how do you start to approach either a composition or an arrangement. You have to start actually just be getting an idea of what it is that whoever you're going to do it for, wants. And then to let it develop in a natural way. And the feeling for it, and the idea of it in your mind, let it develop in a natural way. So if you say you want a composition and you have a certain instrumentation, that instrumentation alone can inspire you a place to start. Once you get a place to start then the rest of it is natural development after that. I've had situations where I've been commissioned to do things for the Joe Henderson big band CD and when they gave me the composition, the first thing I try to do is find a melody. If you find a good melody — see because a good melody stands by itself. That's an arrangement, that's the composition, that's everything, the theory and everything. If you find a good melody then the rest of the things are going to fall into place see. So if you're going to arrange something for instance, you find a song that inspires you to arrange. And actually I feel like, except for people that write just to make a living, the only way that a person should approach an arrangement is by inspiration. So that whatever they're inspired to do will leave some kind of long lasting musical standard that inspires the next person to write something that's valuable. So I would start probably with finding a melody. And from that melody I would find the introduction later, the interludes, the way it's going to resolve into other melodies, the way that it's finally going to develop.

MR: Does the individual you're writing for shape the way you write also?

SH: Well it can, you know if you have people that you really are familiar with and love the way they play. But you still have to write — I like to write something that anybody can play it and enjoy it. The enjoyment of the musician is one of the very first things to me, that they enjoy playing it. Because I know that if they enjoy playing it they're going to get a certain feeling across to the people that are listening to it. That inspiration is going to make everything. Because see music is not — when you write music down, that's not music. Music is what somebody interprets from that thing that you write down. And that's when the music starts is when the musicians get it and decide what they're going to do with it and start to develop it. See whenever you heard some of the recordings and things that we liked of the big bands, Glenn Miller, Duke Ellington, Count Basie, they had played that music for a long time before they recorded it see. They didn't go in the studio like we do now, they give you a whole bunch of new music and you go in there and learn it and record it. I mean it's still new to you. There's so much that you could do if you really get to know it.

MR: That's true. Those songs that they recorded back then had been tweaked and just gotten to that wonderful point where they were ready to record. Wow. Do you — this is kind of a technical question — do you write a transposed score when you work?

SH: A transposed score. I could easily write a concert score, but you know what I think about? I think about the poor guy that has to transpose it. You know?

MR: That's nice of you.

SH: Let him do all of that transposition, you know. I think man, boy that must be a job. So I always did develop the transposed score approach. And I also write with a pen or pencil. I don't use computers or anything like that. I enjoy writing the traditional way.

MR: Yeah. Well it also helps I guess if you're writing a transposed score is you actually know what you're asking these people to pull off — from a saxophone standpoint and that whole thing.

SH: That's true, the range. Because when you write a concert score you still have to keep in mind the range of the instruments and everything.

MR: If you look at a piece that you're writing and you look down beat one of a particular measure that you've written, how much of that can you hear in your head?

SH: Well what I do, I'm writing a score right now and it's for two flutes, clarinet, bass clarinet, nine violins, three violas, two cellos, bass, three trombones, three trumpets, piano, bass, drums, guitar, percussion. And what I do is I think everything starts off, usually to me, I mean in life, things usually don't hit you right over the head. They usually start off as something, maybe as a smaller approach to a conversation or whatever, rather than just coming in and really throwing a lot of words at you. You know, so I start off with the thing being not too — I don't like to start off with everything at once. I like for it to start small and develop. Because I think it does a lot of good for the human ear and for the people that are going to listen when they have a chance, if you give them a chance to get used to it before you throw the whole thing at them. Some people like to throw the whole thing right in the beginning. When I'm playing it's the same way. I like to start my concerts not too fast, not too loud, not too big. Just give the people a chance to let their ears get used to the music. And then as they do then you can given them some more dissonant things, some more volume and stuff like that, in and out of those things. So I like to let a thing develop from a small beginning, in and out, and use more of the instruments, not use them all through the whole thing, change and like that.

MR: Is there ever a temptation to give somebody something to play because they haven't had anything to play in a while?

SH: In the ensemble?

MR: Yeah.

SH: Well it's not really a problem because actually when you're looking at the score you always are inspired to use, probably more often than not, things that don't have to be there. The whole idea I find is the simplicity is where you get the most value out of the thing. When you can write simple. That means that when you do write complicated or write the whole ensemble it has more of a purpose. But you can always use, especially if you have good musicians. That's the thing that affects it. The level of musicianship that you're dealing with. You can write one person playing when it's a really good musician, and it will have a good effect. But if it's a musician that doesn't have very much experience and you write them by theirselves it can feel uncertain. But you know all the instruments can always be used in so many ways to make the different colors, the different effects, and to make as much variety as possible. That's very important.

MR: You've played an awful big role in Dizzy Gillespie's career.

SH: Well a little.

MR: Well I think you had a good positive effect on what he was able to do. Would you agree with that?

SH: Well I'll tell you, we have to look at that. Because I joined Dizzy's band in either the late fifties or the early sixties. And the band that I joined was the band with Lee Morgan, Benny Golson, Wynton Kelly, Melba Liston was the musical director, and they were playing so much music man, my head was just — they had my head spinning. I never wrote anything for the band. Because the music that they were playing, the arrangements were so good that I just didn't feel like I wanted to try to write something coming up to that level of arranging that they were doing. So actually I was just learning. I wasn't able to contribute much or anything. They had all the great soloists there, they had the great arrangers there and everything. Dizzy was even writing himself, and Dizzy was playing fantastic himself. His chops were strong. And they were playing all these great arrangements. So I didn't contribute that much to him until later when I joined the United Nations band. I started doing some writing for that. But it was always still very intimidating to be writing for him, because he was such a great arranger himself. Standards were very high.

MR: Yeah. Is there certain things that he liked to hear? Is it possible to answer that? I mean certain tempos, feels? I know he loved Latin grooves.

SH: Well he liked Latin things but he didn't mind it not being Latin. The thing that he looked for was the sincerity of the essence of the arrangement or composition. They were very — all of their arrangements had a real strong expressive aspect. That was the thing that Dizzy's band introduced into music that made a lot of guys feel like they wanted to avoid facing the reality of what they were doing because they weren't writing things just to write a good arrangement. Those arrangements had a definite purpose and they were

really very inspired by that whole concept of music that those guys were coming from which was a concept of music that dealt with people that had to be doing a lot of work on what they were doing, a lot of studying and a lot of practice, virtuosity in the music in general, that's what Dizzy's band was about. So they wrote things that you had to work on. If you weren't a virtuoso you still had to do a lot of practice to try to play whatever it is that they wrote. So the music was based on that kind of thing, you know, it was a very sincere music and the music had a lot of feeling and a lot of expression, and was very inspiring to all the music world in general. So that's where he was coming from.

MR: He was a pretty spiritual person?

SH: Yeah he was into a lot of different spiritual things though. He had different spirits.

MR: I see.

SH: He ended up in, what was that —

MR: B'hai?

SH: The B'hai, yeah. The spiritual thing that comes from the East and things like that. But I think that he was more, Dizzy was just more of a great spirit in himself. More so than what he could really get out of religion. I guess he looked in there for some reason, but he had a great spirit himself. You go back and see this guy that came from a place in the south where he was living in a situation where racism and all of that was really rampant. And this guy just went through all of that like it was nothing. And Dizzy, see Dizzy was — in school Dizzy would skip a grade whenever he wanted to. He was that smart. So his brother that was next older than him, he skipped until he got into the class with him and then he finished school with him. He's a brilliant guy you know. The kind of guy that could hear a language and things and just on his own figure out exactly how the theory of a language should be. He was like that. But you heard from what he played, his mind was working incredibly fast and on a very sophisticated level. And at the same time he could come right down to earth and be as down to earth — more down to earth than you can stand actually.

MR: Like how?

SH: Well Dizzy could talk with a person from any level of the society and speak an English that was just incredible. Then he'd come right down and speak with the guys that had no education at all, and feel completely comfortable with them. It's fantastic. I never was able to do that.

MR: Quite a sense of humor, too.

SH: A wonderful sense of humor. Could have been a comedian if he wanted to. But he always brought a lot of humor and a wonderful feeling to the people that work with him, and he treated the people with a lot of love — the musicians with a lot of love. He was one of the best band leaders around.

MR: Has there been a time, from an economic standpoint, that's been toughest in your career, a period of years?

SH: Not really. I find that all the things about economics and all of that that's a problem for me, are problems that I made myself. It wasn't what was happening in society or in general. It was whenever I had a problem with those things I made that problem myself. And when we were coming up we were so interested in learning we never thought about money. You know we were practicing all day man. People were sick of us. They'd say you guys are crazy, you're never going to do anything, you're spending all this time playing all this funny music. And we loved it so much we never were offended, we never though about oh we're going to make money or we're not going to make money. We never thought about that. All we thought about, man how can we learn to play a C seven, how many different ways can we play a C seven? That's what we were doing every day, from the morning to night.

MR: This is the group in Indianapolis. Were you in the same school? Freddie Hubbard and those guys?

SH: My brothers and sisters were. Yeah they were all in Attucks High School.

MR: Okay. But it was just a congregation of people that had that same passion.

SH: Yeah there were a lot of musicians there — there were classical musicians and the jazz musicians were studying together. They were actually trading experience and knowledge with each other. And we'd get together and play, we'd get together and read music just for the fun of it, and we'd get together and try to write an arrangement and have somebody to play it. It was horrible, but we were so glad to have the opportunity to try. That was that thing that we thought about.

MR: Yeah. To get to hear those things, and experiment, and find out what works and what doesn't.

SH: It was wonderful. It was wonderful just to think that it might sound like something. And often it didn't. But we enjoyed the part before we heard that.

MR: Oh gosh. I didn't ask you about the Black Artists' Orchestra, the Manhattan Composers' Orchestra.

SH: Oh yeah. That orchestra I think Jimmy Owens had a great deal to do with that orchestra. And I got to write quite a few things for them. It was a wonderful experience because I was free to do whatever I wanted to, usually some kind of direction in the program, but it was a chance to have the freedom as far as the things that I wanted to try, the things that I wanted to experiment with and all of that. It was a wonderful opportunity for me so I think I had a chance to do a lot of good things there, to learn a lot was one of the main things. And the guys were very willing to try all kinds of things.

MR: What did you think of the — I guess they would have called it the avante garde period, free jazz and so forth, that Ornette was doing and some of Coltrane's later work.

SH: We did a lot of that in Europe already before I came back you know. In fact in Europe they had some subsidy for projects that were based on free music, that means that you were usually doing things that were somewhat unusual to the way that you usually approach composing or writing music. And I thought it was a thing that had a good effect on, in general, on our musical growth, because it was a chance for us to experience something different in music. And it was a chance to do something that ordinarily would — well it gave us a chance to be completely free. Okay what happens when you're completely free, and see what happens. The only thing that I didn't agree with about it is when you have a musical concept that's new, I think you should always still have a relationship to the music that comes before so that you can see where that relates to the music. Don't always — you shouldn't always jump off and do something that you can't tell if it has anything to do with all the stuff that came before, because all the music that came before is the reason that something should happen. Sometimes people make it happen because they didn't want to have a contact with the thing that happened before, and things don't happen like that. Things develop from one stage, and they don't all of a sudden, the glacier didn't all of a sudden jump from North America then jump to South America. It would have been a mess if it had. So music is the same way. You can't disconnect it.

MR: I see.

SH: You can be as advanced as you want, but don't disconnect it. Still keep the development process in a natural process from the traditional thing, come all the way up and go as far as you want to, but somehow be able to go back and see how that line connects. Because that's the way nature is. And no matter how much we want to do a thing we still have to go by the rules of nature.

MR: Yeah. That's very interesting again. And you've also done some work in I guess you could call it the popular music field with some Motown artists and that kind of thing?

SH: Yeah.

MR: How did that come about.

SH: Well that was during the time when the trombone actually was becoming quite unpopular in the States. That was in the sixties after I had played with Dizzy's band and Art Blakey and you weren't hearing much about trombones doing any recordings or anything like that. But this guy Berry Gordy and some other people that knew about me because I had worked with Lloyd Price's band as the musical director, so they wanted me to come out there. Because they actually wanted to start some kind of a jazz label. I don't think — they said they wanted to start a jazz label, but I don't think they knew what they really

meant. They didn't mean the same thing that we might have meant. But when I went out there and I started working as a conductor, I was conducting shows, I was conducting Stevie Wonder and the Four Tops and all of that stuff, and some of the big shows and things. I went into some of the studios where they worked, I went to the studios and they had a way of writing that was really unique. I really — you couldn't just be a good writer and go out there and take part in that. There was something special they had. And when I went in and listened to it and heard it I said this is something different. This is something that they really feel. That's the way it developed. So it wasn't — I wasn't able to really contribute a lot. I did some arranging in special situations, but I wasn't able to get in to that stuff that they were writing behind the Supremes and all that. Those guys did that better than anybody.

MR: Who were those guys?

SH: The group that did all the recording was called The Funk Brothers. That was the rhythm section. They had a lot to do with it because they would get a very simple lead sheet and they would develop the music that we heard out of that lead sheet. But there were some other guys that were writing that — they had several writers that were doing the arrangements. And those guys, there were about four or five guys, and they had a special way of writing that was really wonderful for that music.

MR: Yeah when you listen to like "My Girl," the way that tune develops and eventually the string parts fit in and they mesh with what has already been going on which just continues throughout the song is really, as you said, pretty special.

SH: There's some thought that went into it. And it's with the feeling. It wasn't only a system, it was a feeling. Because I listened to it and I was trying to see what is this that they're doing. But I couldn't really catch it. I guess I didn't really find it. It's interesting, that I might have felt when I listened to bebop I had to find out what was going on, so I listened for hours and listened to all the CDs and went over stuff and everything. But there I was listening to see if I could understand that concept. I didn't, but I did enjoy what they did though.

MR: Um hum. Who were the favorite people that you might have backed up back then, or conducted for?

SH: Well the one group that I worked with was the Four Tops. I conducted more for them. And the Four Tops — I actually had some wonderful stories with those guys. Because they were a group of guys that was together making music because they loved to make music together and they were beautiful people too. And they told me some wonderful stories and I heard recently that they were — after they moved to California Billy Eckstine wanted to record with a group like the Four Freshmen, but he couldn't get them but the Four Tops were there. So said, "Can you guys sing like the Four Freshmen?"

They said, “Sure we can.” And they went in for an hour or so and worked on some stuff and came back out and said okay this is it. And they sang some stuff like the Four Freshmen. And then they made a whole CD together with those guys singing behind him. They were like that. They were guys that really loved to work together They had had a great experience together, good and bad. And I conducted for them and did some writing for them and I really liked those guys.

MR: Who was the lead singer? Otis?

SH: Scruggs. LeRoy Scruggs.

MR: Scrubbs or Stubbs?

SH: LeRoy Scrubbs or Stubbs.

MR: Yeah. A very identifiable sound.

SH: Yeah. They were a great group. They brought a lot of good feeling to wherever they worked.

MR: Have you ever had to work a non-music job in your career?

SH: I tried.

MR: You tried.

SH: Oh you mean since I’ve become a musician?

MR: Yeah.

SH: No. No after I became a musician I didn’t have to go outside to work anything. But before, before I became a professional musician I had a job as a waiter, and I dropped my first tray.

MR: Your first tray.

SH: My first tray. So the guy said, “Don’t worry about it,” he said, “everybody drops their first tray.” That was my last tray too.

MR: I think it was prophetic. Well it was good for the music business that you dropped your first tray.

SH: Filled with dishes you know, in this big hotel, luxury restaurant.

MR: Oh.

SH: People were like this.

MR: More recently you took on a big — it would seem like a challenge to me — with doing “A Love Supreme,” with was it the Carnegie Hall band?

SH: The Carnegie Hall Band, yeah. I didn’t do a very good job.

MR: Oh you’re saying that again.

SH: Great songs. Have you listened to that CD?

MR: Yeah.

SH: By ‘Trane?

MR: Yeah.

SH: It's a great CD.

MR: Lord, I wouldn't know where to start.

SH: That's why actually I go back and say oh my arrangement definitely didn't make it. Because the music they played was so high on there.

MR: Well I would agree that it would be very hard to capture that intensity. I don't care how many guys you have.

SH: Yeah.

MR: Sometimes all those people can't match what happened with those four individuals.

SH: I was missing the point. I missed it. And what I need to do with "A Love Supreme," I need to listen to that album for a year. Because there is so much music there that you can't just get all of that really fast and know what's going on there. I had to do it too fast. And when I was listening to the CD I was thinking man, this is a lot of music in here. And every time you listen to another track there's a lot of music in there, and then there's a lot of music all the way through the whole thing. So my arrangement wasn't — it was a good idea but it didn't make it.

MR: What percentage of your own work do you feel like that about?

SH: Well most times what's happening was I was going too fast. Having to finish too fast.

MR: Deadlines. Right? You're given a deadline?

SH: Yeah. One time before I was working — before I was working with deadlines — and deadlines are funny things. When you have a deadline you have to find out how you can arrive at that deadline with the most quality in what you're doing. And a lot of times trying to get there fast is the worst way to go there. I found out recently when you have something that you don't have much time to do, make sure that you're rested first so your mind will work on the highest level that it can. And then even if you can't spend a lot of time on it, the time that you spend you'll be producing the best music that you can find. But if you work tired it's going to take the quality of the music down. So that's what I did many times when I was making deadlines. So now what I do is I take all the time that I need until I really enjoy what it is that I'm writing, I don't put it down.

MR: So if you got a call to do some writing and we need this next Thursday, would you most likely turn that down?

SH: Most times I would turn it down. I would recommend somebody that I know does those deadline things very well.

MR: Who are your — the people that were your contemporaries that you enjoyed as far as arrangers?

SH: Well of course I guess one of my first inspirations was — there were so many guys — but Billy Strayhorn was one of my first inspirations. And a lot of people when they listen to Duke they don't know how much of that work was done by Billy as far as the

orchestrations are concerned. Duke was the inspiration but Billy was the guy that really was the orchestrator. And I really like Billy, I love Billy. And I love a lot of the guys that wrote for Dizzy. I love Gil Evans. I think that Gil was one of the most complete of all of the guys. Because I was listening recently to some of his older arrangements. I was in Holland and they played the older things. "Robbin's Nest," "Anthropology" and all that. And you could get an idea of where he was going. But when he finally got together with Miles it was all there. And those things that they did are just really — that's some of the greatest arranging that I've ever heard. There are other great arrangers, good arrangers, but that was complete. That was not just an arrangement, that was orchestration, composition, arrangement, everything together.

MR: Orchestration is a whole skill in itself, don't you think?

SH: Yeah. I learned that from "Peter and the Wolf." The orchestration is bad. The melodies are humorous you know, but the orchestration is bad.

MR: I agree. And like — what's the Tchaichovsky they always play at Christmastime?

SH: Yeah. That's with the "Dance of the Sugarplum Ferry."

MR: "The Nutcracker."

SH: "The Nutcracker." That's bad. Orchestration is incredible.

MR: So you can learn, you know, you can learn from—

SH: Yes from that man. All you have to do is look at those scores. You can learn everything about orchestration. Because that guy was really rough man. What was going on in his mind, I'm telling you.

MR: Boy what he could have done with the Ellington band.

SH: Oh boy.

MR: And you know it's interesting too because those — I don't think that guys like Tchaichovsky were actually writing for individuals either. So they didn't have that extra — like Ellington had such individuals.

SH: Yeah he knew what they could do. But those guys, they wrote for inferior musicians actually. A lot of times the guys that were playing in those ensembles might have been a butcher or, you know, he's out butchering stuff before he played you know. So they were thinking about — they were able to even think past the fact that they didn't have all the guys to play the music then like the guys do in classical music now. They wrote it anyway.

MR: What's your feeling about jazz today?

SH: Well I've been asked that question recently and see the wonderful thing about jazz is where jazz comes from and why is the thing that answers when people think is jazz going to live, is it going to die? Jazz is one of the only art forms where people have the freedom of expression. And you don't have to say anything bad about anybody to do what you

feel. You don't have to do anything that actually rubs anybody the wrong way to do what you feel. There's no language where you're saying anything that offends — you don't offend anybody. You don't make anybody think that personally you're attacking them. It's the only thing that you can do that with. You can express your exact feelings, and somehow people from everywhere have experienced those same things that you're feeling. Jazz is one of the only things like that. So jazz is a music that comes from a very natural part of the human race in general. The thing that's different about it is that it doesn't allow any person or group to control it. That's one of the most dangerous things about it. It makes people free. And all the big countries that are like the countries that have strong political parties and all of that, that's frightening to them. Because the one thing they don't want is for a person to have their own opinion about things. Jazz gives you the chance to have your own opinion. And that's one of the really fantastic things about it. Even more than the music is that it gives you the chance to express how you're feeling and also say yeah, well he had the right to say what he feels too. You have the right to play the way that he plays just as much as I do. And that's what makes it wonderful is that all these different rights give you all these different possibilities and inspirations and all of that. So jazz will always exist. Because people have to, unless they finally just put everybody in the thing and just make them do whatever they want them to do forever, and even then there'll be somebody slipping around trying to play a blues chorus.

MR: Very interesting. What's coming up in the near future for you?

SH: Next week — Paris, London, and then we're going to fly over, I'm going to fly over to Paris because I have to do business in Paris and then I'm going to London because we're coming back on the QE II and we're playing for the whole way back with the Dizzy Gillespie Sextet.

MR: And who is in that group now?

SH: This time will be Terrell Stafford, Antonio Hart, I think Renee Rosnes, John Lee and Dennis Mackrel. And they're giving us the best cabins on the boat.

MR: All right. I like Antonio Hart. He reminds me of Cannonball some, who was my absolute hero.

SH: He's a talented guy. This guy has so much talent, man, he's got to find some way — you know, hold him. He's brilliant man. He knows so much. He loves music so much that he just, you know, it's probably hard for him to relate to too much outside of music. And it's been wonderful working with him because he's a very serious — whatever he plays he's very serious about it. He plays a lot of different styles you know. But see when I was in Berlin I worked with Leo Wright. Leo Wright and Carmell Jones. We were in one of the radio bands together. And Leo could play every style of music that there is, and played

them all with conviction. It was one of the most fantastic things I ever saw. He could play country-western, he could play the blues, he could play old style, he could play traditional, he could play straight ahead, he could play like Trane. It was unbelievable. And the guys were actually mad at him because the guy could play so many styles they hired him for everything. He could read everything in sight. Tony's got a lot of that in him.

MR: Did you ever have occasion to work much with the Adderley brothers?

SH: Not much but I have worked with them. One of my experiences, well I guess one of my main ways, not to work with but I worked on the same concert with Miles when Cannonball was there and Trane, and also when J.J. and Nat Adderley were together in the quintet. I was with Maynard and they were opening the concert with their band. And that was — but I've also recorded with Nat. I did a very bad CD with Nat too, I played very badly on that. It was very nice of him to give me the opportunity to do it. But I played some tuba on that CD.

MR: What was the name of that?

SH: I don't know. I wanted to forget it.

MR: Oh, okay. I probably have it.

SH: He did some wonderful arrangements of things though.

MR: Well it sounds like your calendar and your plate remains full.

SH: I worked so much in the last few months. I was working so much that I couldn't get to practice or anything. Now I'm able to practice. I'm practicing and writing, because I have these things coming up where I have to do all my own music and all of that for the radio and things like that. So I'm getting a chance right now, all day long I'm practicing and writing. And it's just a wonderful feeling.

MR: Is it hard to keep a big band fairly consistent from a personnel standpoint?

SH: Almost impossible. When you have good musicians they're always doing a lot of other things. So you can never keep a band with all the same guys anymore. There was a time when you could do that. But not now. All good musicians have a lot of projects of their own that they're doing, so you get them once in a while but not very often.

MR: It must be hard to just mount one concert.

SH: It really is.

MR: To get a rehearsal in and scheduling.

SH: It's a job. When we did the trombone album, the trombone CD, we did that one thing, but we could never have that same group again. But we had good guys after that too, guys that weren't on the CD. And when we did the trombone thing recently at the Blue Note with Bobby Burgess and Bill Watrous you know, those guys and Benny Powell, they love to work together so they'll just about do anything they can to get to work in that group

because they loved being there so much. But in general when you've got a group like that it's hard to get that group together more than once. There always will be some change in there.

MR: Have you had good or bad luck dealing with record companies over the years?

SH: Well in a way you can look at it two ways. It was good that you got to record as far as the popularity is concerned. But record companies have a very strange business ethic. Very strange. And it isn't good for the artist. And I haven't understood yet what it is that they're trying to achieve. It looks like they're mainly building up a catalogue and then selling it. That seems to be what they're — they never seem to try to keep the record company building in a way that it's going to last. Because for some reason they don't really believe in paying royalties see. But now in Europe they pay royalties. See they've got some organizations over there like Cessane in Germany, GAMA, you have to pay royalties over there. If somebody whistles your music on the street they've got to pay. If a band plays your song — a marching band — they have to pay. And in the clubs if you play and you don't put all the music down they'll say well we were there on Thursday night and you played Thelonious Monk and you don't have it on here.

MR: These are representatives of those organizations?

SH: Yeah.

MR: Wow.

SH: It's wonderful.

MR: Especially for the writers.

SH: Yeah. They have a great respect for composers because they had all those great composers in the classical music over there so that developed from that time.

MR: Yeah. Do you think jazz over there has a little bit of the — I don't know if exotic is the right word — but the fact that it came from somewhere else gives it a little more juice.

SH: Whether they appreciate it more because of that. No their appreciation for jazz is just like their appreciation for all art forms. They live for art. This is so important for them, to go to a concert. They will pass up a meal to go to a concert. They've been developed that over many years, that whole appreciation for art. They treat artists over there — they would have given Charlie Parker a city over there. They tried to get him to stay. They would have given him whatever he wanted. So it's appreciation for art that they have. They'll go 500 miles to hear a concert.

MR: Well maybe because most of those countries are a lot older than the United States.

SH: They're real old. Yeah, they're definitely old.

MR: It's taken all that time. So we'll look to the future.

SH: The States is doing pretty good, the United States is doing pretty good with their appreciation of art now too. I was watching television the other night and they had on the

Mostly Mozart series at Lincoln Center, and the guy was playing piano, he was playing really great too. And the people in the audience, they were smiling and they were applauding after each part.

MR: Was this on last night?

SH: Yeah.

MR: I saw it too.

SH: They were applauding after each part of the composition. They don't usually do that.

MR: Right.

SH: They're supposed to wait 'till the end.

MR: They couldn't wait 'till the end. Right. It was like a jazz club. Well this has been most fascinating for me.

SH: I enjoyed it very much.

MR: And I really enjoyed — you have a great deal to say and a great way of saying it and I appreciate it.

SH: Well thank you very much. I've enjoyed it very much. My pleasure.

MR: And good luck on that big boat coming back. That should be a lot of fun.

SH: Yeah that will be. We're on — almost in the penthouse.

MR: All right.

SH: So I'm just going to practice up there man.

MR: The people are going — you get right out there on the terrace and do that. All right. Well thanks again. And I'll be listening for your next group, and see you and so forth.

SH: Okay. Enjoyed it.